of Indian officialdom.[51] The communists announced their intention to 'liberate' Tibet almost as soon as they won power in October 1949. Nevertheless, precious little was done to thwart Chinese designs. When Tibet turned to India for help, 'requesting formal recognition of its independence as the basis of bringing before the United Nations any attack as international aggression',[52] its request was turned down. Anglo-American requests for cooperation in transferring military aid to Lhasa were similarly denied.[53] In January 1950, for example, when Secretary of State Dean Acheson considered inviting a Tibetan mission to Washington and inquired whether the Indian government would be willing to cooperate with the United States in helping strengthen Tibet's military capacity, he received a negative reply from Foreign Secretary K.P.S. Menon.[54]

Hugh Richardson, the representative of the Indian government in Tibet, recommended that in the interests of its own security, India respond positively to Tibetan demands and reiterate that its recognition of Chinese suzerainty was predicated on Chinese acceptance of Tibetan autonomy: both flowed from the 1914 convention, and India could not claim one and repudiate the other. India's disregard of the convention, he warned, would expose it to renewed territorial claims by China. Patel gave similar counsel, reminding Nehru that India had maintained bilateral relations with Tibet on the same basis that the British had.[55] Both pieces of advice were ignored; in fact, Hugh Richardson was painted as violently anti-Chinese and working to incite Tibetans.[56] Long-established policy was jettisoned as Nehru refused to challenge the legitimacy of Chinese claims to sovereignty.

Being the sole country to have inherited legal rights and obligations rooted in Anglo-Tibetan treaties, both the West and Tibet itself thus looked to India to take moral leadership on the Tibetan question. Instead, not only did India fail to openly confront China's aggressive claims, it also facilitated the manifestly unequal and coerced negotiations between the People's Republic and the Tibetan government, with the Indian government telling the Tibetan mission that there was no hope for them but to negotiate